

The Midlands Potato Economy

A Strategy for Expanding British Potato Production, Supporting Walkers Crisps, and Building an Export-Led Snack Manufacturing Cluster

Executive Summary

Few consumer products are as closely associated with British manufacturing as Walkers Crisps. From its manufacturing base in Leicester, Walkers has become the largest crisp producer in Britain, producing more than 11 million bags of crisps every day and processing approximately **800 tonnes of British potatoes each day**. This equates to roughly **290,000 tonnes of potatoes per year**, sourced from hundreds of British farms.

This paper argues that the next stage of growth should not simply focus on manufacturing efficiency, but on rebuilding the agricultural supply chain across Lincolnshire and the wider Midlands. By expanding domestic potato production and strengthening regional logistics, Britain could lower supply-chain costs, increase resilience, support rural employment and create opportunities for higher-value crisp exports.

The Leicester–Lincolnshire Food Corridor

The Midlands already possesses many of the ingredients of an integrated food manufacturing cluster.

Leicester provides:

- one of the world's largest crisp manufacturing facilities
- highly automated food processing
- established distribution networks
- access to the M1, M6 and East Midlands logistics corridor

Lincolnshire is one of Britain's most productive agricultural counties, renowned for potatoes and other vegetables, while neighbouring counties such as Nottinghamshire, Leicestershire, Northamptonshire and Cambridgeshire also contribute significant arable production.

Instead of viewing agriculture and manufacturing separately, they should be considered as components of a single regional industrial ecosystem.

Understanding the Scale

Walkers currently processes approximately:

800 tonnes of potatoes every day

Equivalent to approximately:

- 5,600 tonnes per week
- 24,000 tonnes per month
- 290,000 tonnes annually

This means the factory requires a continuous flow of high-quality potatoes every day of the year.

Agricultural Requirements

Average UK potato yields vary depending on weather, soil and variety, but commercial crops commonly achieve around **40–50 tonnes per hectare**.

Using an illustrative yield of **45 tonnes per hectare**, supplying 290,000 tonnes annually would require approximately:

6,400–6,500 hectares

or roughly

64 km²

of productive potato land.

This is a relatively modest area within the broader East Midlands agricultural landscape, suggesting that supplying a major processing facility is feasible as part of a diversified farming sector.

The Economics of Scale

The greatest opportunity lies not simply in producing more potatoes but in reducing the average cost of production through scale and supply-chain efficiency.

Larger regional production can support:

- greater investment in storage
- precision agriculture
- irrigation
- harvesting equipment
- transport optimisation
- long-term grower contracts

As production expands, fixed costs are spread over more output, reducing average costs even if the cost of producing each additional tonne eventually begins to rise because of land, labour or environmental constraints.

For Walkers, a more efficient domestic supply chain could reduce transport complexity, improve crop consistency and strengthen resilience against weather-related disruptions or international supply shocks.

The Lincolnshire Potato Cluster

Rather than relying solely on individual farms, government and industry could encourage a coordinated "Potato Cluster" across Lincolnshire and neighbouring counties.

Potential investments include:

- regional grading facilities
- modern cold storage
- seed potato research
- irrigation infrastructure
- autonomous harvesting technology
- agronomy research
- rail-connected logistics hubs

Such investments could improve productivity while supporting rural employment and innovation.

Manufacturing Expansion

A larger domestic potato industry could encourage additional investment in food processing.

Potential developments include:

- expanded crisp production
- premium crisp lines
- export-oriented packaging
- frozen potato products
- dehydrated potato ingredients
- snack innovation centres

This creates additional value beyond primary agriculture.

Export Opportunity

Britain has traditionally exported high-quality manufactured food products rather than bulk agricultural commodities.

The same logic applies to crisps.

Instead of exporting raw potatoes with relatively low value added, Britain can export branded snack products that incorporate:

- manufacturing
- packaging
- flavour development
- marketing
- logistics

Each stage adds economic value before export.

Potential markets include:

- Europe
- North America
- Australia
- East Asia
- the Gulf states

where established British brands already enjoy consumer recognition.

Regional Economic Effects

A stronger potato-processing cluster would support:

Agriculture

- higher-value crop production
- investment in farm technology
- increased demand for agronomy services

Manufacturing

- factory investment
- engineering
- automation

- packaging

Logistics

- warehousing
- refrigeration
- transport
- distribution

Research

- crop science
- food technology
- sustainability
- precision agriculture

Productivity Through Integration

The greatest gains arise from integrating the entire supply chain.

Farm

↓

Storage

↓

Processing

↓

Packaging

↓

Distribution

↓

Retail

↓

Export

Reducing delays, spoilage and transport distances can improve productivity and reduce waste without necessarily increasing the amount of land under cultivation.

A Midlands Food Manufacturing Strategy

The long-term vision is the creation of a Midlands food manufacturing corridor centred on Leicester and supplied by Lincolnshire and neighbouring counties.

Such a strategy would encourage:

- resilient domestic food supply chains
- advanced agricultural technology
- investment in processing
- rural employment
- export growth
- higher-value manufacturing

The objective is not simply to produce more potatoes, but to transform them into higher-value manufactured goods that strengthen Britain's food industry and export capability.

Conclusion

Walkers Crisps already demonstrates how agricultural production and advanced manufacturing can work together. Processing around **800 tonnes of British potatoes each day**, the Leicester operation depends on a sophisticated domestic supply chain built around British growers.

Expanding productive potato cultivation in Lincolnshire and the wider Midlands, combined with continued investment in storage, logistics and processing, could reinforce that competitive advantage. While any expansion would need to remain economically viable, environmentally sustainable and responsive to market demand, a coordinated regional strategy could strengthen both farming and manufacturing.

In this vision, the potato becomes more than an agricultural crop—it becomes the foundation of a modern Midlands industrial cluster that combines farming, food technology, manufacturing and exports into a resilient, high-value regional economy.